DEFENCE JOURNEY

CDS English Notes

Grammar, vocabulary, ordering of sentences and comprehension for the CDS English paper

CDS | ENGLISH

The CDS English paper has **120 questions for 100 marks** in 2 hours (each question 0.83 marks, 1/3 negative marking). It is the most scoring paper if you know the rules, because the questions test grammar, sentence structure and vocabulary. Since all candidates (IMA, INA, AFA and OTA) write it, a good score here decides your rank.

Question type	Approx. number	Key to success
Spotting errors / Sentence improvement	25 to 35	Grammar rules (Sections 1 to 6)
Synonyms and Antonyms	10 to 15	Daily word learning (Section 8)
Ordering of words and sentences (para jumbles)	15 to 20	Logical flow, link words (Section 10)
Idioms and phrases, one-word substitution	10 to 15	Revision lists (Section 9)
Cloze test and fill in the blanks	10 to 15	Prepositions, tenses, collocations
Reading comprehension	15 to 25	Daily reading (Section 11)

TIP: The pattern changes slightly each year. Check the latest UPSC notification before the exam.

1. Parts of Speech and the Sentence

- Eight parts of speech: noun, pronoun, adjective, verb, adverb, preposition, conjunction, interjection.
- A sentence needs a **subject** and a **predicate**. A **clause** has a subject and a verb. A **phrase** does not.
- Kinds of sentences: simple (one clause), compound (two clauses joined by and, but, or), complex (a main clause and a subordinate clause).
- A **participle** or **gerund** phrase must refer to the correct subject. Wrong: *Walking down the road, a snake bit him.* Right: *Walking down the road, he was bitten by a snake.*

2. Subject-Verb Agreement

- Singular subject: singular verb. Plural subject: plural verb. The verb agrees with the **subject**, not the noun near it: *The quality of these mangoes **is** good.*
- Subjects joined by **and** take a plural verb. If they refer to one thing, use a singular verb: *Rice and curry **is** my favourite dish.*
- **Either…or, neither…nor, or, nor**: the verb agrees with the nearer subject.
- **Each, every, either, neither, everyone, anybody, nobody, one of** take a singular verb.

- **With, along with, as well as, together with, in addition to** do not change the number of the verb: *The teacher, with his students, **was** present.*
- Singular in form: *news, mathematics, physics, economics, politics, measles*. Plural only: *scissors, trousers, cattle, people, police*.
- **Many a** + singular noun takes a singular verb: *Many a student **has** failed.*
- **A number of** takes a plural verb. **The number of** takes a singular verb.
- Expressions of time, money, weight and distance, taken as a whole, take a singular verb: *Ten kilometres **is** a long distance.*

3. Tenses and Verb Forms

Tense	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect continuous
Present	writes	is writing	has written	has been writing
Past	wrote	was writing	had written	had been writing
Future	will write	will be writing	will have written	will have been writing

- Simple present for general truths and habits: *Water boils at 100°C.*
- **Since** (point of time) and **for** (period) go with perfect tenses: *He has been ill since Monday / for three days.*
- After **if**, do not use *will* in the if-clause. Type 1: *If he comes, I will go.* Type 2: *If he came, I would go.* Type 3: *If he had come, I would have gone.*
- After **wish**, **as if**, **if only** (unreal situations): use the past or *were*: *I wish I were taller.*
- Use the past perfect for the earlier of two past actions: *The patient had died before the doctor arrived.*
- Words like **yesterday, last week, ago** need the simple past; **already, just, yet, ever, never** need the present perfect.
- **Had better, would rather, let, make, help** are followed by the base verb without *to*: *You had better go.*
- **Verbs followed by -ing:** enjoy, avoid, finish, mind, practise, suggest, stop, deny, admit. **Followed by to + verb:** want, hope, decide, promise, refuse, plan, manage, afford.

4. Articles, Adjectives and Adverbs

- **a/an:** the sound decides: *a university, a European, an hour, an honest man, an MLA*.
- **the:** for a particular thing; with rivers, mountain ranges, seas and oceans, newspapers and unique things: *the Ganga, the Himalayas, the Sun, the Hindu*.
- No article with names of persons, most cities and countries, languages, subjects, meals and sports: *He plays cricket.*
- **Comparison:** use comparative for two (taller than) and superlative for more than two (the tallest). Do not use double comparatives (*more better* is wrong).
- **Elder/eldest** refer to family members. **Older/oldest** refer to age in general. **Later/latest** refer to time. **Latter/last** refer to order.
- **Few, a few, the few:** (almost none, some, all the little available). **Little, a little, the little** work the same way with uncountable nouns.

- **Fewer** is used with countable nouns, **less** with uncountable nouns: *fewer chairs, less furniture.*
- **Adverbs** modify verbs, adjectives or adverbs. *He ran **fast**. She is **very** clever.* Hard and hardly, late and lately, near and nearly differ in meaning.
- **Enough** comes after an adjective but before a noun: *He is tall enough. He has enough money.*

5. Prepositions

Use	Rule	Example
Time	**at** a clock time, **on** a day or date, **in** a month or year, **by** a deadline	at 6 pm, on Sunday, in 1947, by Friday
Place	**at** a point, **in** an area, **on** a surface	at the station, in Delhi, on the wall
Two or many	**between** two, **among** many	between the two brothers, among the people
Direction	**to** shows movement, **into** shows entering	went to school, jumped into the river
Cause	**die of** a disease, **die from** an injury or accident	died of cancer, died from a wound

Word + preposition	Word + preposition	Word + preposition
abstain **from**	accuse **of**	acquit **of**
adhere **to**	aim **at**	ashamed **of**
blind **to** (fault)	capable **of**	comply **with**
conducive **to**	confident **of**	contrast **with**
deprive **of**	differ **from** / differ **with** (opinion)	disgusted **with**
embark **on**	exception **to**	familiar **with**
fond **of**	guilty **of**	indifferent **to**
part **with**	preside **over**	prohibit **from**
resort **to**	sympathise **with**	yearn **for**

6. Pronouns, Conjunctions and Common Errors

- Use the **subject form** as subject (I, he, we, they) and the **object form** as object (me, him, us, them): *Between you and **me*** (not “you and I”). In formal grammar, use *It is I* and *It was he*.
- **Who** (subject), **whom** (object), **whose** (possessive). Use **which** for things and **that** after superlatives and words like all, any, only.
- **Reflexive pronoun** (myself, himself) is used only when it refers to the subject: *I hurt myself.*
- A pronoun must agree with its antecedent in number and person: *Each of the students must bring **his** book.*
- **Conjunction pairs:** either…or, neither…nor, not only…but also, both…and, whether…or, no sooner…than, hardly/scarcely…when. The two parts need parallel forms.
- **Because, since, as** give reasons. **Although, though, even though** show contrast but are never used together with **but** in the same sentence.
- **Superior, inferior, senior, junior, prior, prefer, preferable** are followed by **to**, not *than*.

- **Rise** (intransitive) and **raise** (transitive). **Lie** (rest) and **lay** (put). **Sit** and **set**. Check whether the verb needs an object.
- Avoid **redundancy**: *return back, repeat again, reason is because, free gift, close proximity* are wrong.
- **Parallelism:** keep the same grammatical form in a list. Wrong: *He likes swimming, to run and reading.* Right: *He likes swimming, running and reading.*

7. Voice, Narration and Sentence Improvement

- **Passive voice**: be + past participle. *The police arrested the thief → The thief was arrested by the police.* A sentence with no object (intransitive verb) cannot be passive.
- **Direct to indirect speech:** change the tense one step back, and change pronouns and time words: *now → then, today → that day, yesterday → the previous day, tomorrow → the next day, here → there, this → that.*
- Questions in indirect speech use **if / whether** or the question word, with normal word order: *She asked where he lived.*
- Commands become *told / ordered / requested + to + verb.* Universal truths do not change tense.
- **Sentence improvement:** read the underlined part, spot the error (tense, preposition, agreement, wrong word order, redundancy), then choose the option that fixes it without creating a new error. Option (A) is always 'no improvement'. Pick it only after you have checked carefully.
- **Question tags:** positive statement gets a negative tag, and the reverse. *He can swim, can't he?* The tag of *I am* is *aren't I*. The tag of *Let us* is *shall we*.

8. Vocabulary: Synonyms and Antonyms

Word	Synonym	Antonym
Abandon	desert, forsake	keep, retain
Adversity	hardship, misfortune	prosperity, good luck
Ambiguous	unclear, vague	clear, explicit
Arrogant	proud, haughty	humble, modest
Candid	frank, open	evasive, secretive
Contempt	scorn, disdain	respect, admiration
Courteous	polite, civil	rude, impolite
Diligent	industrious, hardworking	lazy, idle
Elated	overjoyed, delighted	depressed, sad
Fragile	delicate, brittle	sturdy, durable
Genuine	authentic, real	fake, false
Hypocrite	pretender, deceiver	sincere person
Impartial	fair, unbiased	biased, partial
Meagre	scanty, inadequate	ample, abundant
Novice	beginner, amateur	expert, veteran
Obsolete	outdated, old-fashioned	modern, current
Persevere	persist, endure	give up, quit
Reluctant	unwilling, hesitant	willing, eager
Serene	calm, peaceful	turbulent, agitated
Tenacious	persistent, firm	weak, yielding
Vindicate	justify, clear	accuse, blame
Zenith	peak, summit	nadir, bottom

9. Idioms, One-word Substitution and Foreign Phrases

Idiom	Meaning	Idiom	Meaning
A bolt from the blue	a complete surprise	At loggerheads	in strong disagreement
A hot potato	a controversial issue	Bury the hatchet	end a quarrel
Cry wolf	raise a false alarm	Add fuel to the fire	make matters worse
Hand in glove	very close or in partnership	Make both ends meet	manage on little money
Face the music	accept the punishment	Pull one's leg	tease or joke with someone
Kick the bucket	to die	Throw in the towel	give up
Leave no stone unturned	try every possible means	Put up with	tolerate
Out of the blue	unexpectedly	Take to heart	feel deeply about
Raining cats and dogs	raining heavily	Cold feet	sudden fear or doubt
Tooth and nail	with all one's strength	Wild goose chase	a useless search

Meaning	Word	Meaning	Word
Government by the few	Oligarchy	Government by the best	Aristocracy
One who walks in sleep	Somnambulist	One who lives alone	Recluse
A person who talks too much	Garrulous / Loquacious	Able to use both hands equally	Ambidextrous
That which can be eaten	Edible	That which cannot be corrected	Incorrigible
Fear of heights	Acrophobia	Fear of water	Hydrophobia
Murder of one's brother	Fratricide	Murder of one's father	Patricide
A place for keeping birds	Aviary	A person who is hard to please	Fastidious
Speaking many languages	Polyglot	That which is common to all	Universal
Left a will behind	Testate	Not left a will	Intestate

10. Ordering of Sentences (Para-jumbles)

- Find the **opening sentence**. It introduces the topic, uses a noun (not a pronoun) and does not depend on a previous sentence.
- Spot **mandatory pairs**: two sentences that must stay together (a question and its answer, a cause and its result, a noun and the pronoun that replaces it).
- Link words show the order. *However, but, therefore, thus, hence* never start a paragraph. *Firstly, to begin with* start it. *Finally, lastly, in conclusion* end it.
- **Articles** give a clue: *a* or *an* introduces a new item, *the* refers back to something already mentioned.
- Check the options. Remove the options that start with a wrong opening sentence first. Then test the rest.
- Read the final order again to see whether it tells a smooth story.

11. Reading Comprehension and Cloze Test

- Read the questions first. Read the passage once, underlining the main idea of every paragraph.
- The answer must be **supported by the passage**. Never use outside knowledge or your own opinion.
- For **word-meaning questions**, look at the sentence before and after. Test each option by putting it in the sentence.
- **Tone / attitude questions:** read the adjectives and adverbs the writer uses. Options with extreme words (*always, never, entirely*) are usually wrong.
- For the **title or central idea**, choose the option that covers the whole passage and not just one example.
- **Cloze test:** first read the whole passage to understand the theme. Then fill the blanks by checking grammar (tense, preposition, agreement) and then meaning. Do not fill blanks in isolation.
- Improve by reading one editorial every day. Underline new words and write their meaning in a vocabulary notebook.

Commonly Confused Words

Pair	Meaning
accept / except	receive / other than
adapt / adopt	adjust / take up formally
affect / effect	to influence (verb) / result (noun)
alternate / alternative	every second / another choice
beside / besides	next to / in addition to
complement / compliment	completes / praise
council / counsel	a group / advice
disinterested / uninterested	impartial / not interested
eminent / imminent	famous / about to happen
historic / historical	important in history / related to history
principal / principle	head of a school or main / rule
stationary / stationery	not moving / writing materials